The Approval Letter Came: What to Do With It First, and What Can Wait

Three moves, in order, and what to leave for later.

Mom's approval letter came this week. You've read the first line three times, the relief was real, and page two is still waiting. Nobody has said what the family does now.

Start here. Three things, in this order.

1 Read the letter to the end, then give it a folder

The federal booklet Medicaid: Getting Started says a state that approves someone for coverage sends an approval letter, and this is it. Read all of it, including the back. On a sheet of paper, copy down in the letter's own words: the date on it, every other date it gives (including the one it calls the effective date), anything it says the family is to do, send or keep paying, and the phone number for questions. Then put the letter in a folder of its own. [1]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST The letter is the agency's own account of what it decided and what it expects. Everything else on this page refers back to it.

2 Give the Medicaid mail one home and one calendar

More envelopes may follow. Choose one place where every letter from the Medicaid agency goes, in date order, and one person who opens them. Put any date a letter mentions on a calendar, noting which letter it came from. Then check that the agency has a current mailing address and phone number for letters about Mom. The federal renewal flyer lists that first: make sure the state has your current contact information, then check your mail. [2]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST The agency tells a family what it needs by letter. A letter helps only when it reaches someone who opens it.

3 Start a list of what has changed since the application

The application described one moment. On one page, write what is different now or about to be: Mom's income, her accounts, where she lives, her care, and any money that has arrived or is expected, each with a date. Don't decide whether a change has to be reported. Write it as a question for the Medicaid agency or your Medicaid planner. The nonprofit Justice in Aging notes that changes in a person's life can change their Medicaid eligibility, and that states have procedures for people to report them. For the money lines, the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide for people managing a relative's money suggests a record of what is received and spent, with dates and reasons. [3] [4]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST A change is easiest to ask about while you still remember the date. The list is your side of that conversation.

What can wait

- Working out what each line of the letter means for Mom. Copy it down and ask.
- The next renewal. For now it's a question to write down: when is it, and what will the agency ask for?
- Deciding which changes have to be reported. That answer comes from the Medicaid agency or your Medicaid planner.
- A full filing system. A folder, a calendar and a list are enough for this week.

Two things that come first

If a letter asks the family to send something or fill something out, that comes ahead of everything on this page. The federal renewal flyer says to send what a letter asks for as soon as possible. If you can't tell what it wants, call the number on the letter or bring it to your Medicaid planner.

If money arrives that nobody expected, or someone suggests giving, selling or moving money or property, ask your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney before anything is done. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide says to get legal advice and be very careful about decisions that may affect a person's eligibility for Medicaid.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't interpret the approval letter, say what has to be reported or when, or decide anything about Mom's money. Nothing in it is legal, financial or tax advice. It puts the first few moves in order.

Ready for the next step?

You've read the letter to the end, given the Medicaid mail one home and started a list of what has changed. The planning interview takes it from there: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The approval letter and the advice to keep contact information current, check the mail and send what a letter asks for come from the two federal publications below. The statements about changes in circumstances come from Justice in Aging, and the record-keeping and legal-advice points from the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau. The order is ours.

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (Medicare.gov publication, CMS Product No. 11409, April 2026), Medicaid: Getting Started
2. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS), Have Medicaid or CHIP? Get ready to renew your coverage
3. Justice in Aging, Final Rule to Streamline Access to Medicaid
4. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else's money: Help for agents under a power of attorney